

Ahmedabad

Imagine a city that handles a massive modern metro expansion with one hand while holding a 600-year-old architectural masterclass with the other. We're talking about Ahmedabad, India's first UNESCO World Heritage City. To get under its skin—and to see if the rather sharp VinFast VF 6 can handle the chaotic poetry of its historical heart—we teamed up with Aniruddh Thakore, the man behind the 'Apni Dharohar' Instagram handle that aims to preserve the heritage of this city's evolution through walking tours.

Our first proper pitstop is the grand gateway of the old walled city. Tucked into a dusty corner is a flickering flame, the Akhand Jyot, dedicated to Lakshmi, the goddess of wealth. Aniruddh retells the local lore—a royal guard caught a mysterious woman trying to sneak out of the gates late at night.

As we silently cruised across the Sabarmati river in the VF 6, Aniruddh dropped a brilliant bit of philosophy. He reckons the river is the absolute present tense. Cross it one way, and you are stepping out of a time machine into the ancient past; cross it the other, and you are launching straight into a futuristic metropolis.

In the old city, we parked up and went on foot into the Pols—these tightly packed, labyrinthine housing clusters that make up the Old City. Here, we stumbled upon a "live memorial" for Dalpatram, a legendary 19th-century Gujarati poet and social reformer. Instead of some unapproachable bronze statue on a high pedestal, this lifelike figure sits